

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Fall Series 1
Painting the Stars ~ A Renaissance of Wonder
6 September 2026



*Hubble Space Telescope image of a star-forming
Credit: Hubble and ESA*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on SALZBURG and BUNESSAN

Paraphrase of Tomaso Vitali's Chaconne in G minor

Meditation on "Cao Cung Lân" (Dúc/Xyên, adapted by C. Bull)

A Tribute to Dolly Parton (Dolly Parton, arr. C. Bull)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Rev. Lehman & Betsy Sullenger

We gather now,
harvesters of an all-pervasive grace,
unexpected benefactors of the deed
to this great and glorious cosmic inheritance.

We, the walking, waking stars, ablaze with
wonder,
imagination,
and hope,
gather to remember three words: *kinship* with all
that is;
debt, that can only be paid forward;
gift, sacred
mantra of the humble.

Creation,
the great and glorious sacrifice of abundance, asks
in return-
only-
that we shed our entitled egos
and drop to our knees,
uttering a single, simple prayer
that changes everything:
'Thank you.' [bsanguin]

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Creation

SALZBURG

Let the whole creation cry, "Glory be to God on high!"
Heaven and earth, awake and sing, to your God your praises bring.
Sun and moon, uplift your voice, night and stars, in God rejoice;
Sunshine, darkness, cloud, and storm, rain and snow in praise perform.

Chant in honor, ocean fair; earth, soft rushing through the air;
Birds, with morn and dew elate, sing with joy at heaven's gate.
Let the blossoms of the earth join the universal mirth;
Men and women, young and old, raise the anthem manifold.

You to whom the arts belong, add your voices to the song;
Bards of knowledge and of law, to the glorious circle draw.
From the north to southern pole let the mighty chorus roll:
"Holy, holy, holy," cry; "Glory be to God on high!"

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

Holy One,
sometimes we forget
that we carry around
in our bodies,
and in our luminous minds,
the entire universe.

Illumed One,
despite knowing that each carbon atom
in our blood and firing neuron in our brain
came from ancient stars,
we still ignore our own radiance.

Too often, Mysterious One,
we cannot see the miracles
that are right before our eyes.

*Help us, O God, in this time
to see your light shining upon us
and help us God to look to the stars
so that we might see your light around us,
among us, and within us -
on this day,
and on all the days to come.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

Light of a Clear Blue Morning
Laude, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*

DOLLY PARTON/arr. DAVID HARRIS

***The Lord's Prayer**

Betsy Sullenger

*Weaver of Life, Ancient and Unfolding,
How sacred is your Presence!
We lean on your guidance.
We seek your love.*

*We open to your transformation.
Provide us bread in body and spirit
to sustain us in faith and solidarity.
Companion us with grace
as we seek to live lives of forgiveness and compassion,
repair and accountability.
We remember those who have supported us
as we seek to support others
in all the mess and glory of this human journey.
Guard our minds and hearts from the temptation of domination
and turn our loyalty away from the systems of evil.
For the whole cosmos hums with your wisdom.
Everything that lives, returns to your care.
Our thanks and honor to you,
Gracious Web of Existence,
Our Source and our Home.
Amen and Amen.*

[enfleshed]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

In the rising of the sun and its setting,
in the glow of the moon and its seasons,
in the infinity of space and its shining stars,
we experience God with gratitude.

This morning, may we know the harmony of heaven
in the relationships of earth
and may we know the expanse of its mystery
within ourselves and within each other.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

Betsy Sullenger

from the Psalms

Psalm 19:1-4

The heavens herald your glory, O God,
and the skies display your handiwork.
Day after day they tell their story,
and night after night they reveal
the depth of their understanding.
Without speech, without words,

without even an audible voice,
their cry echoes through all the world,
and their message reaches the ends of the earth.

from the Prayer of Azariah

**Blessed are you in the high heavens, O God.
Let the sun and moon praise you.
Let the stars and all that shines with glory praise you.
For you are the God of all creation.*

This is the witness of the people.
Thanks be to God!

*The Prayer of Azariah is a passage that appears after Daniel 3:23 in Roman Catholic and Eastern Orthodox Bibles, as well as in the ancient Greek Septuagint translation.

Prayers with the People
Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Rev. Lehman

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Eternal Mystery, Heaven's Presence,
Stillest Breath and Deepest Sigh,
we open our hearts
to the presence of Who We Are in this place.

Each of us brings life to this day's possibilities.
We bring hope, or despair,
eagerness or malaise,
joy or sorrow
and with these things we paint the skies above us.

May the beauty of life's fullness unfold in our hearts
that we may loosen
the grip of the mundane on our lives.
May the richness of mystery unfold in our minds
that we may let go of our need for proof.
May the possibility of newness and light
be present to us
that we may unfold the wings of our faith
and soar as into a world changed by our possibilities.

May we see in the skies we have painted
the collective beauty of the world
and the miracle of our presence in it.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

O Virtus Sapientiae
Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*

HILDEGARD VON BINGEN

Sermon

A Renaissance of Wonder

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin
Betsy Sullenger

Invitation to Generosity

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

Silent Noon

Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Soloist*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano*

RALPH VAUGHAN WILLIAMS
TEXT: DANTE GABRIEL ROSSETTI

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Offering Prayer

Betsy Sullenger

O God of the Universe,
we give thanks today
for the Driving Force
at work in our world
that becomes visible
in extravagant generosity
and celebration of being.

We rejoice in the awareness
that we are co-creators with you
of this life,
and we pray for the grace
to accept its responsibilities.

*Help us in these days to work with
the Spirit of Life so that we may
give breath to your dream
for our lives, and for our world.
We pray this in the Way of the One
who taught us how to see.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

The blessings of heaven,
the blessings of the earth,
the blessings of sea and sky.
On those we love this day
and on every human family
the gifts of heaven,
the gifts of earth,
the gifts of sea and sky.
Amen and Amen!

Choral Response

To Sit and Dream

DR. ROSEPHANYE POWELL
TEXT: LANGSTON HUGHES

*Hymn for the Journey

Come See the Fullness

BUNESSAN

God the Creator gave in abundance
All of the wonder we now behold;
Colors of glory, everyday beauty,
Echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall,
Love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living;
Marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – life we've been given;
Beauty and promise, myst'r'y and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose;
Friends for the keeping, strength for the road.
- lyrics by Peggy A. Haymnes

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on "9 to 5" (Dolly Parton, adapted for organ by C. Bull)

Inside The Music

"Today we begin a new series exploring our own creation from the matter of the universe and the dust of stars: our interconnectivity with the particles that have existed before us and will continue with our passing. This great unifying force is a comforting and expansive thought. And so, there is no more fitting start to our morning than the well-loved comforting call from one of the world's great unifiers: Dolly Parton. *"Everything's gonna be alright. It's gonna be ok"*, she reminds us even in her departing, through her stalwart and tireless legacy of standing brazenly and boldly in solidarity with the marginalized, and giving generously of her resources to people in need. *"There is a light in the clear blue morning"* when we commit to helping it shine.

A Renaissance of Wonder is further heard through the sonic universe created by the trailblazing mystic, thinker, artist, poet, and creative Hildegard von Bingen. Her mysticism of the 12th century reawakens our own heightened sense of presence within and throughout the universe even now. *O virtus sapientiae - O Power of Wisdom*, we call, as we seek to connect to that bold present! Which then invites us to be aware of that which surrounds us, celebrated in the Rossetti poem set so powerfully by Ralph Vaughan Williams and sung by Dr. Siadat and Dr. Bull— *"your eyes smile peace. 'Tis visible silence: still as the hourglass. When twofold silence was the song of love."* A renaissance—a reawakening—often comes with its utmost clarity in the living silence—the privilege to rest and to observe. And finally, we sing a

Langston Hughes text from the Harlem Renaissance set powerfully by Dr. Rosephanye Powell, a dream for his enslaved ancestors to have the freedom *"To sit. To sit and dream. To sit and dream about the world."*
~ Dr. Ianthe Marini

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